

The Reviewer's Handbook

A field guide to shipping better merge requests

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Harry Osmar

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The Moment It Clicks

Note

The core idea: you don't get hired for what you know — you get hired for what you can prove you can ship.

You don't lose reviews because you're not careful. You lose them because the value isn't visible. This chapter is the shortest path from "I reviewed it" to "I improved it" — using a system that turns effort into evidence.

1.1 A quick story

You open a merge request and your stomach tightens a little. It's not the work — you could review it — but the gap between what you notice and what you can explain. A good handbook closes that gap with structure, not heroics.

Pro Tip

Quick win: if you can explain *why* a change is risky in one sentence, you instantly sound safer than most reviewers.



The review pipeline at a glance

Good review is the bridge between someone's effort and the team's standards.

How the Loop Works

Each week, pick one concept and attach it to a real change. Build the habit, prove it works, and write down what changed.

Do

Read the canonical adapter first — it's the pattern you'll mirror everywhere.

Don't

Don't copy-paste from a stub; you quietly re-introduce escaping bugs.

CHEATSHEET

Pick one lane, review three changes deeply, evaluate honestly, explain clearly. The work becomes easier when your notes already contain the answers.

